

Amazon's Workplace Ethics

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Amazon, one of the world's largest online retailers, was brought under scrutiny after the firings of Emily Cunningham and Maren Costa in April 2020, women who led a protest effort to advocate for better working conditions (Ferrell and Ferrell 2021). After the National Labor Relations Board determined that the firings violated the law, ethical concerns were raised ever since regarding corporate values, employees' rights, and protection against retaliation (Ferrell and Ferrell 2021). From the immense quotas amid online sales to silenced protest efforts, Amazon serves as a case study about the ethical implications of policies over worker's rights and protections at large.

Ethical Issues in Question

Amazon wishes to push workers back into their corporate roles amid massive online sales. Amazon's expectations are reflected through extreme quotas and strict monitoring systems, which have been stated to contribute to significant workplace stress. While productivity is an essential part of the Amazon business model, it is seen as unfair and overwhelming by many, pushing for employees to negotiate wages, benefits, and workplace protections to compensate. Despite concerns raised by employees, Amazon continues to prioritize productivity and raising the bar on quotas, raising questions about how labor conditions are balanced with efficiency.

This has led to a series of protests that Amazon seems to continuously ignore. Their handling of workplace activism raises concerns about corporate retaliation against employees who advocate for fair treatment. While businesses have the right to enforce policies to maintain efficiency and civility, employees should not fear termination for expressing concerns about working conditions. Amazon fired Cunningham and Costa with the intention to silence them, stating that they were violating an "external communications policy" which was brought with

questioning from more employees (Ferrell and Ferrell 2021). This firing reflects a lack of a proper system to talk about such issues, and Amazon's priorities to mitigate worker's voices as much as possible that employees have no other option but to find an alternative option to express their views. Added the 37 retaliation charges filed against Amazon the past year, Amazon reflects a culture willing to resist workplace activism, limiting stakeholders' (specifically low-level employees in the front lines of packaging) abilities to push for improvements with what appear to be "bogus" policies.

Alternative Solutions

In order to see the long term success of the company, Amazon must go through a total reform of their policies and structure prioritizing workers instead of profits. Amazon could start by revising its workplace conditions to allow employees to be compensated for their arduous work. By strengthening benefits, increasing pay, and offering opportunities for advancement, they can create an environment that gives back to workers accordingly. By meeting worker's deserved needs, productivity would only improve; morale is boosted, job satisfaction will rise, and efficiency will continue to go up and at lower costs of worker's well being.

Amazon should also see the reform of their policies in order to create a culture of open discussion between employees and management. To achieve this, they could start by removing policies which inhibit worker's freedom of speech of current workplace environments. Then, they can create forums, hotlines, or committees that not only foster a transparent environment but also allow employees to express concerns knowing the company set them up with the intention to hear them. Workers should feel empowered to voice concerns without fear of dismissive or retaliatory action. This could also prevent broader public scrutiny, and help Amazon gain a

reputation for listening to their employees and actively focusing on ways to improve working conditions.

Recommendations and Reflection

Amazon should prioritize ethical labor practices while balancing business efficiency. Clearly, Amazon prioritizes business decisions along the lines of a separation thesis, a view which excludes all ethical implications in the name of financial gain. However, the long term survival of Amazon depends on ethical decisions such as strengthening employee protections, ensuring transparency in workplace policies, and prioritizing workers' health. A strive to demonstrate ethical leadership by adjusting monitoring practices, performance quotas, and giving more compensation would still promote a healthier work environment while supporting a more ethical approach to business decisions.

Upon reviewing the circumstances, this decision comes from a mix of prioritizing the company's needs to meet online orders but also help employees feel better protected and supported. Amazon should strive to keep fairness and equality as their practices, and realize that some of these initiatives, although they may reduce profits momentarily, are vital in order to keep up their reputation, employee retention, and future profitability.

References

Ferrell, O. C., & Ferrell, L. 2021. *Amazon faces workplace challenges as online sales remain strong*. Daniels Fund Ethics Initiative Case Bank. Auburn University.